



BEFORE

In June 1862, President Lincoln drafted a Preliminary Emancipation Proclamation to free enslaved people in the Rebel states. He presented it to his cabinet in July.

THE WRONG MOMENT

All members of the cabinet **approved the spirit of the document**. But **Secretary of State William H. Seward** claimed that issuing it now, in the wake of General George B. McClellan's withdrawal from the Virginia Peninsula, would appear as "our last shriek on the retreat." Lincoln decided to **postpone discussion** of the matter until the North achieved a decisive victory.

PRELIMINARY PROCLAMATION

The Battle of Antietam in September 1862 **offered the "victory" Lincoln needed**. Although a tactical draw, Confederate general Robert E. Lee was forced to abandon his offensive into Maryland and retreat to Virginia. On September 22, Lincoln released the **Preliminary Emancipation Proclamation**. The rebel states were offered **100 days to return to the Union** and adopt gradual or immediate emancipation; otherwise, enslaved people in the Confederacy would be "forever free."

Lincoln's Preliminary Emancipation Proclamation of September 1862 offered the Confederate states a chance to return to the Union and retain slavery at least for the time being. In spite of this enticement, none of the rebellious states came back into the Federal fold. Throughout the unconquered South, the Preliminary Proclamation was ignored as an empty measure that presented no real change in how the war would be fought.

Southerners were well aware that enslaved people, through their labor on farms and plantations and their work on entrenchments and fortifications, were vital to their cause. In 1861, the *Montgomery Advertiser* had asserted that "the institution of slavery in the South alone enables her to place in the field a force much larger in proportion to her white population than the North ... The institution is a tower of strength to the South."

The need to act

Lincoln knew this as well, and after the Union's military setbacks in the East during the first year of the war, he was anxious to do something that would make significant and visible inroads against the Confederate effort. At this point, Northern public morale was faltering, pressure from the powerful abolitionist bloc in the